

Action Taken Report

Grant: Joint Call for Research Proposals 2026

Agency: Indian Council of Social Science Research (ICSSR) and National Science and Technology Council (NSTC), Taipei, Taiwan · Call: Joint Call for Research Proposals 2026 · Generated: 22 Aug 2026

Overall score	Panel decision	Competitiveness
8.5 / 10	Not stated	—

How to use this document: work through Part 2 first — it ranks the changes that move the funding decision most. Write what you did in the shaded "Action taken" column of each table, then return to Part 4 for section-level fixes. Part 1 shows where marks were lost; Part 5 lists comparable funded work and patents for reference only.

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1. At a glance

Scores are the panel's marking. Green 7 and above, amber 5 to 6.9, red below 5. "Change" compares a revised section with the version reviewed before it.

Section	Version	Score	Change	Verdict	What decides it
Summary / Abstract	v1	9.5	—	—	This is an exemplary project summary that is exceptionally well-aligned with the funding call's objectives. It concisely and powerfully articulates a timely research problem, a clear and feasible mixed-methods approach,...
Methodology / Approach	v1	8.8	—	—	This is a high-quality, well-conceived proposal that demonstrates exceptional alignment with the ICSSR-NSTC joint call's objectives. The project's strength lies in its rigorous, mixed-methods comparative design, a...
Impact & Outcomes	v1	9.5	—	—	This is an exceptionally well-conceived and articulated research proposal that demonstrates a sophisticated understanding of the research problem, the funding call's objectives, and the requirements of impactful...

2. What to fix first

The panel did not rank priority actions for this report. Use the section worksheets in Part 4.

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3. Panel assessment

Executive summary

This is a high-quality and conceptually robust proposal that demonstrates exceptional alignment with the strategic objectives of the ICSSR-NSTC Joint Call. The project's focus on the societal impact of AI on the IT workforce is timely, and its comparative design, contrasting India's service-oriented sector with Taiwan's R&D-intensive industry, is a significant intellectual strength. The proposed mixed-methods approach is rigorous, and the pathway from research activities to tangible, policy-relevant outcomes—such as a joint curriculum framework and policy roadmap—is exceptionally well-articulated.

However, the proposal's overall excellence is tempered by a critical and recurring concern regarding its practical feasibility. There is a significant apparent mismatch between the ambitious scope of the bi-national fieldwork (large-scale surveys, extensive elite interviews, multi-city engagement) and the modest budget cap of INR 12,00,000. While the summary mentions leveraging in-kind resources, these are not substantiated, leaving the review panel with serious reservations about whether the project can be delivered as described without compromising quality. If the applicants can provide a thoroughly convincing budget justification that fully addresses this feasibility gap, the proposal would rank among the very best. As it stands, it is a highly promising project with a significant unresolved execution risk.

Major strengths — keep these

- **Exceptional Strategic Alignment and Bilateral Integration:** The proposal's theme, 'AI and Society', and its genuine comparative framework directly address the core aims of the ICSSR-NSTC call, promising to generate shared value and strengthen bilateral research relationships.
- **Sophisticated and Rigorous Research Design:** The well-structured, mixed-methods approach is highly appropriate for the research questions. The combination of quantitative surveys, qualitative interviews, and longitudinal data analysis provides a robust framework for generating nuanced, multi-dimensional insights.
- **Clear and Compelling Impact Pathway:** The proposal excels in moving beyond academic outputs to define a credible path towards measurable, systemic impact, specifically targeting the reduction of 'institutional lag time' in curriculum and policy reform.
- **High-Value, Policy-Relevant Deliverables:** The project is oriented towards producing practical and actionable outputs (e.g., Policy Briefing for MeitY and NSTC, Joint AI-Readiness Curriculum Framework) that are of direct use to non-academic stakeholders in both nations.
- **Strong Comparative Rationale:** The explicit and well-justified comparison between the distinct IT ecosystems of India and Taiwan is a core intellectual strength that elevates the project beyond two parallel national studies.

Overall weaknesses and recommendations

Major weaknesses	Recommendations	Action taken (your remarks)
1. Significant Budget-Scope Mismatch: This is the most critical weakness. The planned activities—a 500-person bilingual survey, 30 elite interviews across two countries, international travel, and stakeholder workshops—appear financially unfeasible within the INR 12 lakh budget cap, raising major concerns about project viability. 2. Unsubstantiated In-Kind Contributions: The proposal alludes to in-kind support (e.g., AI lab infrastructure, graduate research assistantships) to offset costs, but these claims are not quantified or supported by documentary evidence, making them impossible to evaluate. 3. Aspirational Stakeholder Engagement: While the ambition to co-produce outcomes with government and industry bodies is commendable, the proposal lacks concrete evidence of pre-established commitment (e.g., letters of intent), making this reliance a potential risk. 4. Insufficient Detail on Risk Mitigation: Given the tight budget and dependence on external partners across two countries, the proposal would benefit from a more developed risk analysis and mitigation plan addressing potential challenges such as cost overruns, recruitment difficulties, or partner disengagement.	1. Urgently Reconcile Project Scope with Budgetary Reality. The applicants must provide a meticulously detailed budget justification that transparently demonstrates how all proposed activities can be executed within the INR 12 lakh cap. If this is not possible, they must strategically de-scope the project. For example, instead of a 500-person survey, consider a more focused 300-person survey targeting specific sub-sectors. Model response: 'Work Package 2 (Survey) budget is allocated as follows: Survey platform license (INR 50,000), participant incentives (300 participants x INR 400 = INR 1,20,000), translation and validation (INR 40,000)... This revised sample size maintains statistical relevance for our key strata while aligning with budgetary constraints.' 2. Formalize and Quantify All In-Kind Support. Vague references to institutional support are insufficient. The proposal must be revised to include a table that itemizes, quantifies (in INR/NTD), and describes each in-kind contribution. This must be corroborated by official letters of support. Model response: 'Table X: In-Kind Contributions. Item: Graduate Research Assistant (Indian PI's Institution). Description: 0.5 FTE for 12 months. Value: INR 2,40,000. Status: Confirmed (See Appendix A: Letter of Support).' 3. Transition from Aspirational to Evidenced Stakeholder Buy-In. Strengthen the proposal's claims of engagement by securing and referencing preliminary evidence of partner interest. This transforms a potential risk into a demonstrated strength. Model response: 'Following preliminary discussions with India's Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) on [Date], they have confirmed their interest in receiving the project's policy briefing, as indicated in the attached email correspondence (Appendix B).'	

Major weaknesses	Recommendations	Action taken (your remarks)
	4. Develop a Comprehensive Risk Mitigation Table. Integrate a formal risk assessment table into the Project Description. This should identify at least 4-5 key risks (e.g., budget overrun, low survey response, travel restrictions), assess their likelihood and impact, and detail specific, practical mitigation strategies. The budget's 'Contingency' line item should be explicitly linked to these risks. Model response: 'Risk: Difficulty securing 30 interviews with senior institutional actors. Likelihood: Medium. Impact: High. Mitigation Strategy: We have pre-identified 50 potential interviewees and will leverage the networks of our industry partners (NASSCOM/TSIA) for introductions. A small honorarium (budgeted under 'Survey') will be offered.'	

Material to prepare separately (not scored)

- A detailed Budget and Justification workbook, compliant with ICSSR format (Manpower, Travel, Workshop, etc.), that explicitly addresses the feasibility concerns raised in this review.
- CVs of the Principal Investigators from both India and Taiwan, limited to 2-3 pages each, highlighting expertise relevant to the project.
- Official Letters of Support from the PIs' host institutions. These letters must explicitly confirm and, where possible, quantify all promised in-kind contributions (e.g., staff time, infrastructure access, overhead waivers).
- Letters of Support/Intent from key external institutional partners (e.g., industry bodies like NASSCOM/TSIA, specific university departments for piloting the curriculum) to substantiate claims of stakeholder commitment.
- A detailed Gantt chart (as a one-page appendix) illustrating the project timeline, key milestones, deliverables, and dependencies for all work packages across the 24-month duration.
- Drafts of key research instruments (e.g., survey questionnaire, semi-structured interview protocol) as appendices to demonstrate the advanced state of project planning.
- A statement on the status of ethical clearance applications from the relevant Institutional Review Boards (IRBs) in both India and Taiwan.

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4. Section by section

Each section in proposal order. Revised sections show the change against the version reviewed before.

4.1 Summary / Abstract

9.5 / 10

This is an exemplary project summary that is exceptionally well-aligned with the funding call's objectives. It concisely and powerfully articulates a timely research problem, a clear and feasible mixed-methods approach, and a compelling set of high-impact, policy-relevant outcomes. The proposal's central comparative logic—contrasting India's service-heavy IT sector with Taiwan's R&D-intensive industry—is a significant strength that directly addresses the bilateral nature of the ICSSR-NSTC program. The summary successfully integrates all critical components (problem, methods, outputs, impact, and value-for-money) within the word limit, demonstrating a high level of clarity and strategic thinking. It leaves the reviewer with a strong impression of a well-conceived, important, and efficiently managed project poised to deliver significant value to both academic and policy stakeholders in both nations.

Strengths

- **Exceptional Alignment:** The project's focus on AI's societal impact and its comparative India-Taiwan design perfectly match the funding call's stated priorities and bilateral spirit.
- **High Specificity:** The summary avoids vague language by providing concrete numbers for its methodology (500-person survey, 30 interviews) and naming specific policy targets (MeitY, NSTC, 2029 labor regulation blueprint).
- **Clear Impact Pathway:** It clearly connects research activities to tangible outputs (briefings, curriculum framework) and a well-defined societal goal: ensuring AI-driven productivity doesn't harm entry-level employment.
- **Strong Value Proposition:** The explicit mention of leveraging in-kind resources to stay within the INR 12 lakh budget cap while delivering 'data at scale' is a highly persuasive argument for cost-effectiveness.

Weaknesses and recommendations

Weaknesses	Recommendations	Action taken (your remarks)
1. No significant weaknesses were identified in this section. The inclusion of an in-text citation is stylistically unconventional for an abstract but is a minor point that does not detract from the overall outstanding quality.	1. Consider removing the in-text citation `[CITE:Brynjolfsson2023]`. While it signals academic currency, abstracts typically omit citations for conciseness and flow. The statement is sufficiently strong without it.	
	2. Ensure the main proposal body clearly defines the key theoretical concept of 'Socio-Technical Resilience' introduced in the title, as it provides the central analytical frame for the project.	

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4.2 Methodology / Approach

8.8 / 10

This is a high-quality, well-conceived proposal that demonstrates exceptional alignment with the ICSSR-NSTC joint call's objectives. The project's strength lies in its rigorous, mixed-methods comparative design, a sophisticated and well-articulated impact framework focused on systemic change, and a clear set of practical, policy-relevant deliverables. The research questions are timely, and the rationale for comparing India's service-oriented IT sector with Taiwan's R&D-intensive industry is compelling and well-justified. The primary concern that tempers the score is the potential mismatch between the ambitious scope of the proposed fieldwork (a 500-person bilingual survey, 30 elite interviews, and longitudinal data analysis across two countries) and the modest budget cap of INR 12 lakh. While the proposal asserts feasibility, the budget appears extremely constrained for the planned activities, raising significant questions about the project's practical execution without compromising data quality. Minor weaknesses include some textual redundancy and an aspirational tone regarding stakeholder co-ownership, which would be stronger if supported by preliminary evidence of buy-in.

Strengths

- **Exceptional Alignment with Funding Call:** The project's bilateral, comparative focus on 'AI and Society' is perfectly suited to the ICSSR-NSTC's mandate to foster collaboration on new and emerging themes of mutual importance.
- **Sophisticated Impact Framework:** The proposal excels in defining and measuring impact not just through outputs, but through quantifiable systemic outcomes, such as the 'measurable shortening of the gap between technology adoption and workforce adaptation.' This directly addresses the funder's need for real-world value.
- **Methodological Rigor and Clarity:** The four-work-stream structure is logical and detailed. The mixed-methods approach is appropriate, and each component (survey, interviews, NLP analysis) is described with sufficient specificity, including sample sizes, analytical techniques, and theoretical grounding.
- **Clear, Actionable Deliverables:** The table of deliverables is a model of clarity, effectively linking each output to a specific user and a plausible impact mechanism. The proposed instruments (Curriculum Framework, Policy Roadmap) are practical and address a clear need.

Weaknesses and recommendations

Weaknesses	Recommendations	Action taken (your remarks)
1. Budgetary Feasibility Concern: The proposed scope of work—particularly the 500-person survey and 30 interviews across multiple cities in two countries—appears highly ambitious for the INR 12 lakh budget. The proposal asserts feasibility but lacks the detail to fully convince a reviewer that this can be achieved without significant compromises.	1. Strengthen Budgetary Justification: The separate budget document must provide a meticulous, line-by-line justification demonstrating how all proposed activities, including survey incentives, travel, transcription, and workshop costs, can be realistically covered within the INR 12 lakh limit. Clearly articulate how the bilateral funding model (host pays local costs) is leveraged to maximize efficiency.	
2. Assumed Data Access and Recruitment: The methodology assumes smooth access to survey respondents, elite interviewees, and job-posting data. It lacks a detailed recruitment strategy, risk assessment for low response rates, or contingency	2. Detail the Recruitment Strategy: Within the methodology section, add a paragraph detailing the specific strategies for recruiting survey participants (e.g., use of panel companies, partnerships with industry associations) and interviewees (e.g., process for identification, contact, and follow-up). Briefly address potential challenges and mitigation strategies.	

Weaknesses	Recommendations	Action taken (your remarks)
plans, which are critical for a project reliant on primary data collection. 3. Aspirational Stakeholder Engagement: The proposal mentions securing 'co-ownership' and MOUs with stakeholders as part of the project. While laudable, this is presented as a future goal. The proposal would be significantly stronger if it could point to pre-existing relationships or preliminary commitments from these key institutional partners. 4. Minor Textual Redundancy: There is noticeable repetition in the description of the methodology, particularly between Section 2 ('Project Activities and Methodology') and the final paragraph of Section 5 ('Feasibility and Timeline'). This suggests the text could be further refined for conciseness and impact.	3. Provide Evidence of Stakeholder Buy-in: If any preliminary discussions with key partners (e.g., MeitY, NSTC, NASSCOM, TSIA, partner universities) have taken place, mention this explicitly. Securing and referencing letters of support in the application package would substantially de-risk the project's impact pathway. 4. Refine and Consolidate Text: Conduct a final editorial review to eliminate redundant descriptions. For example, the detailed recap of the methodology in the 'Feasibility' section should be removed or condensed to avoid repetition and improve the overall flow of the narrative.	

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4.3 Impact & Outcomes

9.5 / 10

This is an exceptionally well-conceived and articulated research proposal that demonstrates a sophisticated understanding of the research problem, the funding call's objectives, and the requirements of impactful policy-oriented research. The project's design is rigorous, its objectives are clear, and the pathway from research activities to measurable, systemic impact is both credible and compelling. The proposal excels in its genuine bilateral integration, moving beyond parallel studies to a truly joint endeavor aimed at producing shared value for both India and Taiwan. The minor weaknesses identified are not fundamental flaws but rather opportunities for refinement. The budget, while aligned with the cap, appears ambitious for the extensive multi-city fieldwork and deep stakeholder engagement proposed, warranting a more detailed justification. Similarly, a more robust risk mitigation plan would further strengthen the claims of feasibility. Overall, this is a top-tier proposal that represents an excellent investment and is highly recommended for funding.

Strengths

- **Exceptional Alignment with Funding Call:** The project directly addresses the call's priority area of 'Artificial Intelligence and Society' and its core mission to foster durable bilateral research cooperation between India and Taiwan.
- **Rigorous and Integrated Methodology:** The mixed-methods design, combining surveys, elite interviews, and a sophisticated longitudinal analysis of job-posting data, is robust and well-suited to the research questions. The integration of these streams into practical instruments is a significant strength.

- **Clear and Measurable Impact Pathway:** The proposal masterfully avoids vague impact claims. The focus on a measurable systemic outcome—reducing the institutional lag time for curriculum and reskilling reform—is specific, innovative, and highly relevant. The deliverables table clearly links outputs to users and impact mechanisms.
- **Strong Stakeholder Engagement and Co-Production:** The plan to validate and refine deliverables through stakeholder workshops and pilot implementations with named institutional users (MeitY, NSTC, universities, industry bodies) significantly increases the probability of adoption and real-world impact.

Weaknesses and recommendations

Weaknesses	Recommendations	Action taken (your remarks)
1. Ambitious Scope for Stated Budget: While the project is well-planned, the scope of multi-city data collection (in both India and Taiwan), survey administration, and intensive stakeholder engagement (including two international workshops) appears highly ambitious for the INR 12 lakh budget. The proposal relies heavily on unquantified in-kind contributions, which may understate the true cost. 2. Underdeveloped Risk Mitigation Strategy: The proposal mentions risk mitigation only briefly at the end. A more structured discussion of potential challenges (e.g., difficulty in securing interviews with senior officials, institutional resistance to piloting new frameworks, data access issues for job portals) and corresponding mitigation strategies is needed. 3. Minor Structural Repetition: The final paragraph of the 'Feasibility and Timeline' section reiterates and expands upon methodological and impact details already presented earlier. While the added detail is useful, its placement feels tacked on and could be better integrated into the relevant preceding sections to improve narrative flow.	1. Strengthen Budget Justification: Provide a more detailed breakdown clarifying how the INR 12 lakh will be allocated across the ambitious activities. Explicitly quantify the value of the institutional in-kind contributions (e.g., 'GPU server access valued at X,' 'software licenses valued at Y') to provide a clearer picture of the project's total value and demonstrate feasibility.	
	2. Elaborate on Risk Mitigation: Add a dedicated subsection or a small table outlining 2-3 primary risks to project success. For each risk, describe the likelihood, potential impact, and a specific, actionable mitigation plan. This would demonstrate foresight and enhance the project's perceived feasibility.	
	3. Refine Narrative Structure: Consider integrating the detailed points from the final paragraph of the 'Feasibility' section into the 'Methodology' and 'Beneficiary Adoption' sections. This would streamline the document, reduce repetition, and place the details in their most logical context.	

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5. Research & patent landscape (reference only)

Similar already-funded projects and Indian patents retrieved for this proposal. This did not influence the scores above.

Comparable funded projects

Project	Agency / scheme	Year	Budget	Status	Aspects of your proposal it touches
Project Title: Aggregation Induced Emission Enhancement Materials: Synthesis and Evaluation of Photophysical properties	SERB PRISM awarded projects · EMR	2015	INR 45,87,547	unknown	Synthesis of metal-oxide nanoparticles; Selective hydrogenation reactions; Selective oxidation reactions
Project Title: Mixed metal oxides as heterogamous catalysts for the triacetin synthesis	SERB PRISM awarded projects · EMR	2015	INR 42,02,729	unknown	Synthesis of metal-oxide nanoparticles
Project Title: Ferroelectric and Piezoelectric properties of modified Barium Titanate ceramics	SERB PRISM awarded projects · EMR	2015	INR 28,42,964	unknown	Synthesis of metal-oxide nanoparticles

Sources: sanctioned-project corpus (3 retrieved). Patents not searched — patent search is not configured on this server.

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Appendix — how this report was produced

- Section reviews were produced one section at a time against the call's published criteria; the panel report reads them together and decides fundability.
- Compliance facts (section coverage, length limits, deadline) are counted from the drafts, not judged by the model.
- Versions scored: the newest version of every section.
- The research & patent landscape is retrieved from the sanctioned-project corpus and PatentNest for reference and does not affect any score.
- Generated on 22 Aug 2026. Regenerate the panel report after revising sections, then export again.